Publishing date statements (date colophons)

Wilbur N. Pickering, ThM PhD

At the end of each of the four Gospels in my Greek Text (according to Family 35), there is a footnote that begins: "In the colophons, **f^{35}** [50%] have, 'published eight [or ten, fifteen, thirty-two] years after the ascension of Christ'." Recently a correspondent asked me for the source of that information. When I went looking for it, I finally found it in Legg's edition of Mark (*Novum Testamentum Graece Secundum Westcotto-Hortianum.* Evangelium Secundum Marcum [Ed. S.C.E. Legg, Oxonii: E. Typographeo Clarendoniano, 1935]). However, Legg's statement of the evidence is generic, and I decided that I should check the MSS for myself, so as to give a precise statement of the evidence. Here is what I found.

I use 'publishing date statements', rather than 'date colophons', because I discovered that the statements occur in a variety of places, not just at the end of a Gospel. (So far as I know, such statements occur only with the Gospels.) It can occur in the introductory statement for a Gospel, in an unusual spot for no apparent reason, and in the case of a commentary MSS, at the beginning of the commentary, especially for Mark. If I found a statement for Matthew, I did not look further; in most cases the others would also have one. A fair number of MSS do not have a statement for Matthew, but they do for Mark. If Mark also did not have one, I went on to Luke, where I found a few. In about four MSS I only found one at the end of John; two of them had a summary statement for all four Gospels. I suggest that such a picture indicates independent activity, not an organized campaign. Since the MSS are copies, not autographs, they repeat an earlier tradition. But where did that tradition come from, when did it start, if it is not true?

When I say that a given MSS has a publishing date statement, it is because I saw it with my own two eyes, and that was only possible because of the work of the INTF (Institute for New Testament Textual Research). Their *Kurzgefasste Liste* (hereafter K. L.) was an indispensable tool [Aland, Kurt (ed.); *Kurzgefasste Liste der Griechischen Handschriften des Neuen Testaments*; Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1994, with supplement]. It lists all the catalogued NT MSS: papyri, uncials, minuscules and lectionaries, except that the lectionaries were not relevant to this study (I went down the list one by one). A very helpful feature of the K. L. is the footnotes, that give the content of the papyri plus other fragments. I did not have to check any MS without the beginning or end of a Gospel. This study would not have been possible without their New Testament Virtual Manuscript Room. It contains PDF images of their microfilms of NT MSS, page by page. When I say, below, that a MS is 'not available', it means that the INTF has not yet posted such images for that MS. Frequently the verse content of a given page is provided beside the image, page by page, but more important for this study was the statement of the verse content at the beginning of each Gospel, with few exceptions. So I could just scroll down to that statement, book by book. Without that help I probably would not have attempted this study. So I say a sincere and heartfelt "Thank you" to all the people at the INTF who contributed to those tools.

Of the 141 extant (known and catalogued) MSS written on papyrus, none have the end of a Gospel, so they are irrelevant for this study. Of the 326 extant MSS written in uncial (upper case) letters, written on parchment (leather), only 28 are relevant for this study (I checked a further

eleven that were 'deficient'). Some 90% of them are fragmentary or have large lacunae; a significant number of them are palimpsests. Of the 28, four have a publishing date statement: G, K, S and Omega (011, 017, 028, 045). S is tenth century and the other three are ninth century. Now then, since those three are copies, not autographs, they had exemplars that had to be older (perhaps by a century or two, or even more), and if those exemplars were copies, not autographs, their exemplars were still older, and so on. How far back do we have to go to find an exemplar that was an original creation, not a copy? In other words, the tradition was probably ancient, and maybe very ancient.

Although the K. L. lists 3327 minuscule MSS, due to repetition and disappearance the actual number of available MSS is somewhat smaller (that includes all MSS, not just those containing the Gospels). I will present the evidence in terms of MSS that I myself checked (there are hundreds of extant MSS that are not presently available on the internet, but I had to access their number in order to find that out). Just by the way, a distinction must be made between 'extant' and 'existent': there are doubtless MSS that certainly exist but have not yet been discovered, so they are not extant. Also, there is a situation like the twenty MSS in the skevophylakion (treasury) of the Megistis Lavras monastery on the Mt. Athos peninsula: we know nothing about them except that they certainly exist, so they are not extant. I have visited that monastery, but the treasury was off-limits.

For this study I made a distinction between commentary MSS and straight-text MSS. A commentary MS was copied to preserve the commentary, not the Text; the Text is secondary. So it was predictable that the percentage of such MSS with a publication date statement would be significantly lower than with the straight-text MSS, and so it proved. I checked 331 commentary MSS. 162 of them were not available, mutilated, or illegible (I did not count 'destroyed'). 123 of them did not contain a publication date statement, including one uncial (033). 46 of them did contain such a statement; here are their GA numbers: 41, 48, 188, 233, 237, 305, 428, 549, 590, 599, 684, 719, 723, 847, 863, 881, 888, 890, 949, 951, 970, 1021, 1029, 1078, 1160, 1252, 1261, 1262, 1263, 1302, 1332, 1336, 1337, 1392, 1506, 1533, 1534, 1536, 1616, 1677, 1678, 2107, 2148, 2188, 2206, 2604. So the percentages are roughly 27% with and 73% without. The few bilingual MSS also do not contain the statement.

And now for the 'main show', the straight-text minuscules. I checked 1715 such MSS that have a GA number, plus seven for which I have a copy, but that did not have a GA number (now they do, but are not available on the internet) [so with the commentaries and uncials I checked over 2,000 MSS]. 253 of them were not available, mutilated, or illegible (I did not count 'destroyed'). 739 of them did not contain a publication date statement. 730 of them did contain such a statement (over 200 of them being Family 35); here are their GA numbers: 4, 6, 7, 9, 12, 13, 18, 28, 35, 43, 45, 46, 52, 53, 55, 61, 65, 71, 72, 83, 90, 98, 105, 111, 113, 114, 116, 117, 122, 124, 125, 126, 128, 132, 141, 147, 153, 155, 159, 160, 163, 167, 173, 174, 199, 201, 205, 209, 211, 214, 218, 224, 230, 231, 246, 263, 264, 266, 267, 276, 277, 285, 290, 292, 293, 297, 330, 339, 345, 346, 347, 355, 361, 363, 367, 376, 386, 387, 388, 389, 394, 399, 402, 408, 409, 413, 415, 417, 420, 422, 435, 443, 444, 448, 472, 478, 479, 480, 482, 483, 485, 486, 489, 494, 496, 502, 508, 510, 512, 516, 517, 521, 529,

530, 531, 533, 536, 538, 543, 547, 551, 553, 558, 564, 575, 577, 586, 587, 588, 594, 597, 645, 650, 652, 653, 655, 656, 664, 673, 680, 685, 686, 689, 691, 693, 694, 695, 696, 702, 706, 709, 713, 714, 716, 717, 725, 748, 755, 757, 758, 761, 763, 764, 765, 768, 769, 774, 775, 778, 781, 785, 787, 789, 792, 795, 797, 799, 801, 803, 804, 806, 808, 811, 824, 825, 826, 827, 828, 837, 844, 852, 867, 871, 872, 873, 896, 897, 901, 902, 903, 906, 922, 923, 924, 925, 927, 928, 932, 933, 934, 937, 938, 940, 943, 945, 947, 952, 953, 955, 957, 958, 959, 960, 961, 962, 966, 971, 973, 979, 981, 983, 986, 988, 991, 995, 996, 997, 999, 1003, 1006, 1009, 1017, 1018, 1019, 1020, 1023, 1024, 1025, 1030, 1031, 1033, 1037, 1040, 1042, 1046, 1050, 1058, 1059, 1061, 1062, 1065, 1068, 1072, 1075, 1081, 1082, 1084, 1086, 1088, 1090, 1092, 1095, 1111, 1114, 1116, 1117, 1121, 1122, 1123, 1126, 1127, 1132, 1133, 1136, 1138, 1139, 1144, 1145, 1146, 1147, 1158, 1165, 1166, 1168, 1169, 1171, 1181, 1185, 1186, 1187, 1189, 1190, 1191, 1192, 1196, 1198, 1199, 1201, 1202, 1203, 1204, 1213, 1214, 1219, 1221, 1222, 1224, 1225, 1226, 1227, 1230, 1232, 1233, 1234, 1235, 1236, 1237, 1238, 1240, 1242, 1247, 1248, 1250, 1251, 1269, 1280, 1285, 1289, 1294, 1298, 1301, 1309, 1314, 1315, 1316, 1321, 1322, 1323, 1324, 1326, 1328, 1329, 1330, 1331, 1334, 1338, 1339, 1340, 1341, 1348, 1351, 1353, 1362, 1383, 1384, 1388, 1389, 1390, 1391, 1394, 1395, 1396, 1397, 1398, 1400, 1401, 1404, 1406, 1407, 1409, 1410, 1413, 1414, 1416, 1425, 1426, 1427, 1431, 1432, 1435, 1436, 1438, 1441, 1442, 1443, 1445, 1447, 1448, 1449, 1451, 1453, 1454, 1456, 1460, 1461, 1462, 1463, 1464, 1465, 1469, 1471, 1472, 1475, 1476, 1477, 1479, 1482, 1486, 1487, 1488, 1489, 1490, 1491, 1492, 1493, 1494, 1495, 1496, 1499, 1501, 1502, 1503, 1508, 1509, 1510, 1511, 1512, 1514, 1520, 1528, 1530, 1531, 1538, 1539, 1543, 1544, 1545, 1548, 1551, 1552, 1554, 1555, 1557, 1558, 1559, 1560, 1562, 1563, 1569, 1571, 1572, 1573, 1574, 1575, 1576, 1577, 1578, 1583, 1584, 1589, 1590, 1591, 1592, 1595, 1596, 1598, 1599, 1600, 1601, 1605, 1606, 1614, 1615, 1617, 1618, 1619, 1620, 1621, 1622, 1624, 1625, 1626, 1627, 1628, 1632, 1633, 1634, 1636, 1637, 1638, 1639, 1642, 1645, 1646, 1647, 1648, 1649, 1650, 1651, 1652, 1653, 1654, 1656, 1657, 1658, 1659, 1661, 1664, 1666, 1667, 1668, 1670, 1671, 1675, 1680, 1685, 1686, 1688, 1689, 1693, 1694, 1695, 1698, 1699, 1700, 1702, 1703, 1704, 1712, 1713, 1779, 1783, 1784, 1786, 1788, 1789, 1792, 1794, 1813, 1816, 1823, 1901, 1966, 2098, 2099, 2112, 2120, 2122, 2131, 2133, 2135, 2139, 2140, 2173, 2174, 2175, 2191, 2193, 2200, 2201, 2203, 2204, 2221, 2236, 2238, 2249, 2250, 2255, 2260, 2261, 2265, 2266, 2273, 2277, 2280, 2281, 2282, 2284, 2291, 2292, 2296, 2301, 2309, 2322, 2223, 2352, 2355, 2356, 2367, 2382, 2387, 2389, 2394, 2396, 2399, 2400, 2407, 2418, 2422, 2444, 2445, 2446, 2454, 2455, 2459, 2460, 2463, 2466, 2467, 2471, 2472, 2474, 2476, 2477, 2483, 2491, 2494, 2496, 2503, 2508, 2510, 2520, 2521, 2533, 2535, 2549, 2554, 2555, 2559, 2561, 2562, 2567, 2586, 2590, 2598, 2610, 2620, 2621, 2623, 2635, 2647, 2649, 2653, 2658, 2660, 2670, 2673, 2686, 2687, 2689, 2691, 2692, 2694, 2699, 2702, 2703, 2705, 2709, 2711, 2713, 2714, 2721, 2725, 2729, 2734, 2735, 2745, 2749, 2753, 2754, 2765, 2767, 2773, 2774, 2775, 2779, 2782, 2783, 2787, 2791, 2806, 2813, 2831, 2856, 2861, 2863, 2875, 2876, 2905, Iviron 2107, 2108, 2109, 2110, 2113, 2114, Leukosia 65. (The Iviron MSS now have a GA number: 2947, 2967, 2968, 2948, 2950, 2969 respectively.)

Since I work alone, without secretary or proofreader, there might be an occasional slip-up. Also, I may have missed an occasional statement in MSS not listed, because it was ‘hidden’ in an unusual place. But none of that will change the big picture. The minuscules divide 49.7% with and 50.3% without the statements. Adding the commentaries and uncials the divide is 46.8% with and 53.2%

without the statements. I cheerfully confess that I am pleased that my guess based on Legg's Mark was so close!

So what may we conclude from this exercise? Virtually any monastery, library or museum with at least five NT MSS will have at least one MS with the statements, and many with fewer also have them. But the monasteries that have them are scattered all over the Mediterranean area. How do we account for the geographical distribution? The statements occur in a variety of places, not just at the end of a Gospel. It can also occur in the introductory statement for a Gospel, in an unusual spot for no apparent reason, and in the case of a commentary MSS, at the beginning of the commentary, especially for Mark. I suggest that such a picture indicates independent activity, not an organized campaign. Since the MSS are copies, not autographs, they repeat an earlier tradition, and we do not know how far back the line of ancestral exemplars goes. I have demonstrated, elsewhere, to my own satisfaction at least, that Family 35 goes back at least to the 3rd century, and it is massively in favor of the statements, 90%. How could a tradition invented in the 3rd century survive and prosper? What if the tradition goes back to the beginning?

If the publication date statements are accurate, they obliterate the presuppositions that underlie any eclectic theory of New Testament textual criticism: that the early Christians did not recognize the NT writings as Scripture; that therefore they made no effort to protect and preserve them; so the original wording became lost beyond the possibility of recovery by objective means; that the transmission of the Text was not normal from the beginning. However, that inconvenience does not invalidate the evidence. Before Jesuit scholar Jose O'Callaghan identified the Qumran fragment 7Q5 with Mark 6:52-53, it had been dated to around 50 AD (and in any case it must be before 70 AD). If Mark was 'published', released to the public, in 40 AD, then 7Q5 could easily be a copy. I freely recognize that I cannot prove that the publication date statements are accurate, but no one can prove the opposite either. I invite the reader to evaluate the evidence for himself.